

CAPITOL REEF:
IS IT WORTH THE VISIT?

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I was halfway through a silent hike along Capitol Gorge when I realized I hadn't checked my phone in nearly two days, and I didn't miss it. I had never actually been inside Capitol Reef; I didn't think there was much to see or do there. When I arrived on the first day, I was absolutely blown away by the views.





Not only was it so breathtakingly beautiful, it surprised me. I was not expecting to fall in love with Capitol Reef like I did, and I found myself saying I needed to come back and bring everyone I know with me.

Well although I didn't mean to forget about Capitol Reef, it flew under the radar for me, my friends and family. Capitol Reef is one of the mighty 5 national parks of southern Utah, and as a born and raised native to the state, you'd assume I've been to all of them.

Arches National Park was our Utah destination of choice, mostly because of the famous Delicate Arch. Little did I know that Capitol Reef not only has 20 sandstone arches, but it also has history hidden within the park.

There is so much to see in Capitol Reef, more than I imagined. I thought it was the boring one of the mighty 5, but I was wrong. Pictured to the left is a school house that was built when the Mormon Pioneers settled in Fruita. It still has antique items inside from the time period, and imagine this view at school.
There is also the Gifford house, a quaint home that now sells homemade goods, souvenirs, and delicious homemade fruit pies.



The Fruita School House

When I arrived at the Capitol Reef Field Station, it didn't look like much, just a few low buildings tucked quietly on a mesa above the Fremont River. But once we stepped inside, I realized how intentional everything was. The water systems, the solar panels, even the toilets were designed for minimal impact.

We weren't just visiting nature, we were learning how to exist within it, responsibly. During a hike near Pleasant Creek, the field station manager gave us a speech about **"LEAVE NO TRACE"** and explained to us how important the impact we make is, leaving a legacy for future generations to also enjoy.



Petroglyphs in Capitol Gorge

Later, as we hiked through Capitol Gorge, sandstone walls rose on either side like giant bookends, etched with time. I ran my fingers along the rock where pioneers had carved their names into the canyon wall, the Pioneer Register. Above that, even older markings: petroglyphs from the Fremont people who lived on the land a thousand years ago. There was no tour guide, no noise, just the crunch of gravel underfoot and the wind brushing against the cliff face. In that silence, I felt something I hadn't felt in a while, total stillness, like the land itself was pausing for breath.



Capitol Reef is also a certified dark sky park, and the views were unbelievable. There were so many stars that I could never normally see. The park is careful about its light pollution so as to keep its certification, providing some of the most beautiful star gazing in the country. while in Capitol Reef, I got to do some star gazing. It didn't feel like looking at stars, it felt like falling into them. I could see the Milky Way stretching across the sky, more stars than I'd ever seen in my life. With no city lights for miles, the darkness was complete and comforting. The field station manager told us about constellations and took us through a meditation. In that moment, surrounded by classmates but somehow feeling entirely alone with the universe, I realized how rare it is to be truly disconnected from the modern world, and how badly we all need that sometimes.

As we drove away from Capitol Reef on the final day, dust trailing behind the van and red cliffs fading in the rearview, I felt like I was leaving something sacred, not just a national park, but a slower, quieter version of myself I'd rediscovered there. Capitol Reef doesn't shout for attention. It whispers. If you're willing to listen and to walk its quiet canyons, look up at its endless night sky, and learn how to move gently through its desert, it'll show you more than just scenery. It'll show you what it means to truly be present. If you're tired of the crowds and craving something real, this is your place. Don't overlook Capitol Reef.

THINGS TO DO IN CAPITOL REEF

Sites

Visitor's Center | Gifford House | School House

Hikes

Capitol Gorge Trail | Cassidy Arch | Hickman's Bridge



CAPITOL REEF: WORTH IT? YES